

G vs. C vs. C'

These three sounds are phonetically similar. The closest English spelling for these sounds would be **ky** or **gy**, but in Witsuwit'en they are spelled without a **y** (the **y** is inherent in the consonant symbol). **c'** is an exploding sound not found in English, but very common in First Nations languages.

In Witsuwit'en, these sounds occur before slightly different sets of vowels. Only **c** can occur at the end of a word.

Examples of g

g must be followed by a vowel, normally one of **i e u i**.

diguh	'mosquito'
gïstan	'six'
degegh?	'what happened (to him/her)?'
netgut	'it (e.g. powder) spilled'
niniges	'it's bending'
Gidimt'en	(clan name)
Gisdewe	(chief name)

g can be found before the vowels **a o** in loan words:

Gonï	'Johnny'
Galim ~ Lïgalim	'Lent'

Examples of c

Before a vowel (**a e ë i**):

can	'rain'
celh	'young man'
cindu	'pine tree'
bicay	'his/her grandchild'
bice	'its tail'
ncagh	'it's big'
biciz	'his/her thumb'
Tsë Cakh	'Tse-Kya, Hagwilget'

At the end of a word:

ts'ac	'bowl, plate'
lhic	'dog'
detic	'door, lid'
hinic	'language, word'
wisnic	'he/she is crazy, wild, uncontrollable'
yelhdic	'he/she is talking'
bidluc	'its handle' (semi-circular)

Examples of c'

c' must be followed by a vowel, normally one of **i e ë o a**.

c'adīh	'ant'
c'ist'ēt	'naked'
c'ilhggic	'mouse'
c'edik	'in the middle'
lhc'ats	'on both sides'
'et lhc'ēgh	'he/she is sitting there mad'

c' is frequently found at the beginning of a word, because one of the Witsuwit'en prefixes is **c'(i)-** 'something, something's'.

c'i'alh	'she's eating something'
c'ik'agh	'bacon' (lit. 'fat of something')
c'ik'iz	'.50, half a dollar' (lit. 'half of something')

g vs. c

niynīlhgez 'he/she bent it'	yinīlhcez 'he/she rendered it (fat)'
gen 'here; old age'	cēn 'summer'

When the vowel **i** follows **g** in Witsuwit'en, **i** has the English "short-i" sound, but when **i** follows **c**, it has the "short-u" sound. (Paying attention to the vowel can help you hear the difference between these consonants.)

gis 'hook'	cis 'feathers; ridge'
gin~ginīh 'don't', as in	cinīh 'marten'
untsagh gin~ginīh 'don't cry'	

c vs. c'

cas 'grizzly bear'	c'azil 'echo'
cel 'spawning salmon'	c'ēldzīn 'moonlight'
cinīh 'marten'	c'inī 'bait'
dicis 'fist'	yizc'is 'he snapped it'
'et silhcoz 'it (cloth) is there'	dic'oz 'it (e.g. cloth, furniture) is sturdy'

g vs. c'

gen 'here; old age'	c'ene' 'maggot'
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Just as above, when the vowel **i** follows **g** in Witsuwit'en, **i** has the English "short-i" sound, but when **i** follows **c'**, it has the "short-u" sound.

dīlhgilh 'it (vapor) is moving'	īlhc'ilh 'bite it'
gis 'hook'	yizc'is 'he/she snapped it'
nigit 'fear'	dic'it 'it is tough (to chew)'

KW, GW and KW'

The spelling of some sounds of Witsuwit'en involves the letter **w**: **kw kw' gw w wh**. These are *rounded* consonants, produced by rounding the lips simultaneously while forming something like a **k**, **g** or other sound. These consonants can occur before any vowel except **u** (and **o** only in certain forms).¹⁴

Examples of gw

Gw is a rare sound in Witsuwit'en. Many speakers have **gw** in the following words, but others may substitute **kw**:

gwe'ilh	'bag'
c'ilhgweh	'it's crooked'
sigwe'	'he/she (baby) pooped'
dilgwikw	'it (marmot) is whistling'
gwisdlunīts, gwislunīts	'mirror'

Examples of kw

kw is found in two contexts in Witsuwit'en. One is before a vowel:

kwin	'fire'
kwis	'cold sickness'
kwile'	'five'
kwa	'again'
c'ikwah	'river'
dzekwil	'earring'
dilkwiz	'he's knocking'
këskwit	'moccasin'
nilkwiy'	'he/she is limping around'

kw also occurs at the end of a word:

hëkw	'go ahead'
tsëldzikw	'comb'
bizikw	'its particles'
nididzikw	'junk, crummy stuff'
dilgwikw	'it (marmot) is whistling'

Some words with **kw** in Witsuwit'en correspond to **gw** in U'in Wit'en/Nedut'en or even more easterly varieties of Witsuwit'en (in regular contact with Nedut'en or Nu'ts'ini):

	Witsuwit'en	U'in Wit'en/Nedut'en
'his/her knee'	bikwit	bigwit
'sled'	kwiz	gwiz

¹⁴The reason for this restriction is that the **w** is too similar to **o** or **u**, which are also produced with rounding of the lips.

(There has apparently been shifting of **gw** to **kw** over time in Witsuwit'en, still on-going.¹⁵)

When the vowel before **kw** is **i**, that vowel absorbs some of the round sound of **w** and almost sounds like **o**:

nt'ikw	'he/she/it is short'
nīlht'ikw	'soon, shortly'
dzut t'ikw ~ dzut'ikw	'vest'
ggut'ikw	'bloodsucker, leech'
bic'ikw ~ bic'oh	'its quills'

This **w**-absorption is particularly likely when the preceding consonant is one of: **b d dz dl g gg gw m n l z y gh w** (the same consonants that do *not* trigger the "u"-like sound of **i**).

nīzdikw	'it's spherical, round (3D)'
nidīlhbikw	'it's spotted'

Examples of KW'

dilkw'akh	'frog'
tsakw'ēt	'muskrat'
kw'it	'short, stubby', as in:
dinī kw'it	'short man'
tselh kw'it	'hatchet'
kw'isil	'bead'
netēzkw'ak ~ netēstkw'ak	'he/she burped'

GW vs. GG, KW vs. K, KW' vs. K'

Kw, gw, kw' are not really back of the throat sounds like **k, gg, and k'**. Compare:

KW' vs. K'

tsakw'ēt 'muskrat'	tsak'ēt 'hole'
bikw'ikh 'his/her (baby's) hat'	bik'ikh 'its tracks'
c'ikw'ëts 'belly (of fish)' (~ c'ik'ëts)	wik'ëts 'afterwards'
kē kw'it 'short, stubby foot/shoe'	hilk'it 'it's swelling up'

GW vs. GG

c'ilhgweh 'it's crooked'	nilggeyh 'he/she is running around'
dilgwīkw 'it (marmot) is whistling'	dilggī 'it's grey'

KW vs. K

Contrasts before a vowel:

kwa 'again'	ka 'car'
bikwit 'his/her knee'	hilkhit 'it's slippery'
nilkwiw 'he/she is limping around'	ts'ilkiy 'it's bitter'
haynīnkwit 'he/she gave him/her a crewcut'	yudīlhkit 'he/she asked him/her'

¹⁵This seems to be parallel to the tendency for some speakers to pronounce **gg** as **k**.

Word-final contrasts:

nt'ikw 'it's short'
nīzdikw 'it's spherical'

nt'ik 'your collarbone'
ndik 'up'

GW vs. G, KW vs. C, KW' vs. C'

Kw, gw, kw' are also not as front-sounding as **c, g, and c'** (which sound like they are followed by y).

KW vs. C

kwin 'fire'
kwis 'cold-sickness'
bikwiz 'his/her sled'

cin 'song'
cis 'down feathers; ridge'
biciz 'his/her thumb'

KW' vs. C'

kw'il 'tap, faucet'

sic'il 'it's broken'

GW vs. G

c'ilhgweh 'it's crooked'
gwidī 'quarter'

'igegeh 'it happened'
gidit'ah 'it's doing this'

IKW vs. OK

As mentioned above, when the vowel before **kw** is **i**, that vowel absorbs some of the round sound of **w** and almost sounds like **o**. But this o-colored **i** is shorter than **o**. Compare the following:

ditlikw 'it's wet'
yilht'ikw 'he/she is sucking on it'
it'
nidilhbikw 'it's spotted'

lhok 'fish'
talok 'sockeye'
weytolht'ok (~weytolht'okh) 'don't let him/her gulp'
gibok 'clam'

WH and W

These are the two remaining *rounded* sounds of Witsuwit'en: **w** and **wh** are produced with rounding of the lips, just like **gw kw kw'**. Both **w** and **wh** can occur before a vowel or after a vowel, but like the other rounded consonants, they do not normally occur before or after a rounded vowel (**u** or **o**).¹⁶

Examples of w

w before a vowel is very common:

wedik
wesiy

'area between two points'
'lynx'

¹⁶There are some exceptions in loan words and chief names; for example, **Wos**. There are also some examples of this sequence after **niwh-** 'our/your (pl.)'. See below.

Widzin Kwah
hiwis
hiwis ~ wiwis
niwis

‘Bulkley R.’
‘she’s ticklish’
‘it foams, foam’
‘soapberries’ (lit. ‘it (berry) is foaming’)

w also occurs syllable-finally:

binewdizigilnikh
welew
bicaw
dimaw (~ dimagh)
widlew

‘I forgot it’
‘there is, are none’
‘its stomach fat’
‘it’s fluffy’
‘spotted sandpiper’

Examples of wh

before a vowel:

whis (~ kwis)

‘thorn’

after a vowel and at the end of a word:

’ewh
newh
tawh
dīwh
lhawh
nawh
 nawh ‘ent’ah
 nawh nānyeyh
ts’iyewh
bighewh
lhighewh
nts’ēwh
biniwh
neclhdzīwh
newilhdzīwh

‘oh dear’ (expression of sympathy)
‘two ways’
‘three ways’
‘four ways’
‘many ways’
‘around there’, as in:
 ‘go away’
 ‘go walk around there’
‘everything’
‘according to it’
‘together, in a cluster’
‘when (in the present or future)’
‘through it’
‘I’m combing’
‘he’s raking’

One source of **wh** in syllable-final position is the second person dual/plural subject (‘you du./pl., you guys’):

īwh’ēn
’ēwht’ēn’
didiwh’as
witsawh’az
witsawhdil
deniwhdec
nelhēwht’ēn’
hibintawhlh’ēlh

‘you (pl.) see it’
‘you (pl.) worked’
‘get up (you du.)’
‘you (du.) came’
‘you (pl.) came’
‘you (pl.) danced inside’
‘you (pl.) saw each other’
‘you (pl.) will look at them’

wh vs. w

welew ‘there is none’

kwilewh ‘five ways’

iw vs. *oh*

The distinction between these three sequences is one of the most difficult topics in Witsuwit'en literacy. It is possible too that not all speakers distinguish them and have a two- rather than three-way contrast. But before we tackle this topic, we should review two things and learn a little about a category called the optative.

Review: stress

Remember that when a Witsuwit'en word contains two syllables (i.e. 2 vowels), the first vowel is *i*, and there are no suffixes, then the stress falls on the second (final) syllable of the word:

bile	'his/her hand'
hinic	'language, word'
silhtsen	'my brother'
bizkak	'his/her children'

If the first syllable contains a vowel other than *i*, then the first syllable gets the main stress:

tabi	'very'
'alha'	'correct'
yecldic	'I'm talking'
'elhghin	'one person'

Compare the following. The word on the left has final syllable stress and the word on the right has initial syllable stress, because of the difference in the vowel of the first syllable.

dini 'person, man'	dini 'you say; 4 people'
dilco 'whole, entire'	delco 'how big is it?'

The optative

The Witsuwit'en *optative* is a verbal category which is marked by a verb prefix, **o-** or **u-**. Of the pairs of words below, the one on the right is in the optative:

sisde 'I'm sitting'	usde 'let me sit, I could sit'
his'alh 'I'm eating it'	us'alh 'I could eat it, should I eat it, let me eat it'
c'is'alh 'I'm eating (something)'	c'os'alh 'should I eat, let me eat, I could eat (something)'

The **o-** form of the optative prefix is used after any of the following consonants:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	,
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

The **u-** form is used after all other consonants and when word-initial. (The optative prefix is deleted after another prefix that ends in vowel.)

The optative is kind of like the subjunctive category of French or Spanish. It is grammatically required when certain other words occur in the sentence, such as the following:

les, lis definite future	usde' les, lis 'I <u>will</u> sit'
wibe 'oondzin 'should'	usde' wibe 'oondzin 'I should sit'
ts'iwelew 'can't, unable'	usde' ts'iwelew 'I can't sit'
gin, ginih 'don't (even)'	unde' gin 'don't sit, don't even think about sitting'
'tell ___ to'	usde' silhni 'he told me to sit'

iw h vs. oh

Remember that when the vowel before **kw** is **i**, that vowel absorbs some of the round sound of **w** and almost sounds like **o** (or like a short o). (Go back and review examples on pp. 60-61 if necessary.)

nt'ikw	'he/she/it is short'
nihlt'ikw	'soon, shortly'
nizdikw	'it's spherical, round (3D)'
nidilhbikw	'it's spotted')

This same **w**-absorption always occurs when **i** precedes **wh**, so that the **i** in **iw h** sounds like a short **o** or even short **uh** (depending on who's talking). Compare the following. The second form is in the optative:

k'ay c'iw h'alh	'you (pl.) are eating now'
c'oh'alh wibe 'oondzin	'you (pl.) should eat'

Both are second person plural subject verbs, so one would expect them both to contain the prefix **wh-**. But after **o** or **u**, the second person plural subject prefix changes from **wh** to **h**. (Remember that rounded consonants do not occur after rounded vowels.) The biggest difference between the two forms above is therefore the stress, which occurs on the final syllable in **c'iw h'alh** and on the initial syllable in **c'oh'alh**. Here are some more pairs which are similar:

'iwht'ah	'work (you pl.)'
'oht'ah wibe 'oondzin	'you (pl.) should work'
niwh'as	'walk around (you du.)'
nuh'as gin	'don't walk around (you du.)'
sdiwhnih	'tell me (you pl.)'
sduhni' niwhilhnih	'he told you (pl.) to tell me'

We also find a limited number examples of **wh** before **o** in forms containing the **niwh-** prefix:

niwhozi'	'your (pl.), our name(s)'
cf. uzi	'a name'
sozi'	'my name(s)'

nyuzi'	'your name(s)'
buzi'	'his/her name(s)'
hibuzi'	'their name(s)'

It may help to know that in word-final syllables, the sequence **iw** seems not to occur. Instead, we find only **oh** there:

ggosoh	'pig'
'o'hoh	'ouch'
'intsoh~'intsuh	'wool yarn'
yilht'oh	'it stung him'
dinildoh	'it (water) is boiling'
kwandoh	'everywhere'

iw vs. o

Finally, there are contrasts between **iw** and **o** in word-final syllables:

Mabel hin 'it'iw 'it's Mabel'	bit'o 'its nest'
ildi'w 'you're cramping up'	nido 'white person'

uclhdiw 'I'm counting them'
 c'ilhghi'w 'he/she is snoring'
 dilghi'w 'it's growling'

Writing practice 8

_____	'shame on you'
_____	'I'm stringing them'
_____	'I strung them'
_____	'he/she is dancing'
_____	'you're dancing, dance!'
_____	'he himself, she herself'
_____	'silk'
_____	'homebrew'
_____	'slingshot'
_____	'last winter'
_____	'it's swinging'
_____	'they say'
_____	'hidden'
_____	'it's warm'

_____	‘it’s oval’
_____	‘it’s dull’
_____	‘gooseberry’
_____	‘spoonhead sculpin’
_____	‘he/she is limping slightly’
_____	‘too, overly’
_____	‘rake’
_____	‘skewer’ (esp. for fish)
_____	‘women’
_____	‘boogeyman’
_____ or _____	‘she’s knitting’
_____ or _____ or _____	‘deer’
_____	‘I wonder’
_____	‘bee’

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Writing practice 8 (answers)

wee
 nis'ës
 nīs'ëz
 nideyh
 nīndeyh
 'adic
 liswe
 'u'ic
 tic'ip
 khiyde'
 nibelh
 hitnī
 wi'ets
 nilwis
 dikilh
 hindistkwitl
 c'indewizgī
 hisiy' kw'akw
 c'intilhw'is
 c'isdewh
 bī newildzīwh
 c'igīwh
 ts'aku
 'ilggu
 c'itl'iw or c'itl'o
 niltiw' or nilto' or niltu'
 lets'ide
 holht'ohgī

'shame on you'
 'I'm stringing them'
 'I strung them'
 'he/she is dancing'
 'you're dancing, dance!'
 'he himself, she herself'
 'silk'
 'homebrew'
 'slingshot'
 'last winter'
 'it's swinging'
 'they say'
 'hidden'
 'it's warm'
 'it's oval'
 'it's dull'
 'gooseberry'
 'spoonhead sculpin'
 'he/she is limping slightly'
 'too, overly'
 'rake'
 'skewer' (esp. for fish)
 'women'
 'boogeyman'
 'she's knitting'
 'deer'
 'I wonder
 'bee'